

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 10.1 – SUMMARY PREPARING TO SIGHT-SING AN UNFAMILIAR PIECE.

RECOMMENDED RESOURCES FOR FURTHER STUDY.



PREPARING TO SIGHT-SING AN UNFAMILIAR PIECE

What do you see and hear when you look at an unfamiliar piece of music?

Throughout this course, we have mentioned various strategies and “best practices” that you, as an experienced sight-singer, should use when encountering a new and unfamiliar piece of music. Here we will summarize them for easy reference.

GENERAL:

- 1) Look at the overall length and structure of the piece:
 - Does it have sections or verses that repeat, or is it “through-composed” (one continuous piece with no sections)?
- 2) Identify the liturgical category (and Tone) of the piece:
 - Is the piece a troparion, a kontakion, a sticheron, an heirmos of a canon, or some other kind of liturgical hymn?
 - If it is in a category that follows the cycle of Eight Tones, what Tone is it in?

RHYTHM:

1) Look at the **tempo** indication:

- Is the tempo fast, slow or medium?
- What is the prevailing pulse? Is it in common time or cut time?

2) Look at the overall rhythmic structure:

- Does the piece have a **time signature** (meter) or is it “unmetered”?
- What are the prevailing note values? (quarter notes, half notes)
- Are there any unusual or challenging-looking rhythmic passages?
- If meter is irregular, are there **triple groupings** (extended beats)? Identify them.

3) Isolate the rhythm first:

- Establish a steady pulse.
- Read and analyze the rhythm using the system of Kodály rhythmic syllables.
- Once the rhythm is solid, singing the correct pitches becomes much easier.

PITCH:

1) Look at the pitch “profile”:

- How many sharps or flats are in the **key signature**?
- What **key** is the piece in? (Sometimes best determined by looking at the very last note or chord) What note is the **tonic** DO? (or LA)?
- Are there any **accidentals** (sharps, flats, naturals) in the melody?

2) Look at **melodic contour** or shape of the melody:

- Does the melody move predominantly by **steps** or by **leaps**?
- Are there any unusual or difficult-looking **intervals**? Identify them and practice them.
- Does the melody have any obvious repeated patterns (**motives**)?
- What is the overall **range**? (What are highest and lowest notes?)

3) After identifying the tonic and locating the starting note, try to **audiate** the melody (sing it in your mind’s ear) using SOL-FA syllables before singing it aloud.

RESOURCES FOR FURTHER STUDY

You have made a great new beginning. But your work isn't finished yet. Persevere and continue to develop your sight-singing abilities! Set aside some sight-singing practice time at least several times a week, and avail yourself of the following resources:

1. *A Common Book of Church Hymns: Divine Liturgy* (Benedict Sheehan, editor)

A 238-page anthology of traditional chant melodies in the mainstream Slavic tradition, written on one staff, and arranged so that it may be sung by one, two, three, or four voices. This book contains melodies for **any** and **all** Divine Liturgies that may be sung throughout the liturgical year. Lots of sight-singing practice!

—available from St. Tikhon's Press

2. **The OCA website** — Services of the Yearly Cycle

This fabulous resource contains Troparia and Kontakia for **every day of the year**, in most cases in several musical settings. A treasure trove of sight-singing material!

If you incorporate these as part of your daily prayer rule or your daily music practice routine, you will not only learn the Eight Tones very thoroughly, but also broaden your horizons with Galician, Serbian, Byzantine, and pattern melodies (*prosomoia*, *podobens*) from various traditions.

3. **The OCA website** — Tutorial for Learning the Tones

All Eight Tones of Stichera melodies in Common (Obikhod) and Kievan Chant are explained in detail, and demonstrated by a choir in sing-along audio tracks. The explanations contain a four-part example of each Tone with SOL-FA syllables written in, offering ample material for harmonic analysis and practice.

“We should read music in the same way that an educated adult will read a book: in silence, but imagining the sound.”

—Zoltan Kodály

**“From spiritual hymns proceeds much that is of value,
much utility and sanctity, for the words purify the mind
and the Holy Spirit descends swiftly
upon the mind of the singer.**

**For those who sing with understanding
invoke the grace of the Spirit.”**

—St. John Chrysostom